MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 1: Socio-Political Background

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Conflicts over monarchy, Parliament, religion, commerce, and public reasoning shaped the literary world from the Stuarts to the eighteenth century.

Start with a picture

Imagine a community arguing about who can make rules, who may challenge them, and where people can publish disagreements. This period changes both the institutions of power and the places where arguments circulate.

1. Stuart rule and conflict

James I succeeded Elizabeth in 1603. Charles I's reign intensified disputes over taxation, royal authority, Parliament, and religion. These issues helped produce civil war; they cannot be reduced to one personal quarrel.

Charles I was executed in 1649. The Commonwealth and Protectorate altered political institutions, while religious and republican debate gave prose and poetry urgent public stakes. Milton's political writing belongs within these conflicts.

2. Restoration

In 1660 the monarchy returned under Charles II. Theatres reopened, and patronage, court culture, and new performance practices affected dramatic writing. Restoration did not reverse every change of the preceding decades.

The 1665 plague and 1666 Great Fire of London also shaped urban experience. Historical context should explain particular pressures rather than turn every poem into a direct report of an event.

3. Revolution and constitutional change

James II's rule ended in the upheaval of 1688. William and Mary's accession and the 1689 Bill of Rights changed the relation between monarchy and Parliament. Political and religious inclusion nevertheless remained limited.

Calling the change “glorious” is a conventional historical label, not proof that every group experienced it as peaceful or liberating.

4. Anne and the Hanoverians

Queen Anne’s reign and the Hanoverian succession form part of the context for party conflict, commercial expansion, print, and new reading publics. Coffeehouses and periodicals supported discussion, but participation depended on resources and social position.

The growth of empire and trade also involved slavery, coercion, and unequal access. Do not describe commercial expansion only as general prosperity.

5. Enlightenment

The Enlightenment values inquiry, argument, evidence, and criticism of inherited assumptions. It was not one doctrine shared by every eighteenth-century thinker, nor did reason simply replace religion.

Ideas of improvement and universal humanity could coexist uneasily with class, gender, and colonial exclusions. Literature can make those contradictions visible.

6. Connecting history with literature

Milton engages questions of freedom, obedience, and authority. Restoration drama examines social codes and performance. Satire tests public pretension; periodical essays address conduct; the novel develops sustained accounts of ordinary experience.

These connections are starting points. A good answer still needs a speech, image, scene, or narrative method as evidence.

Quick check

1. What happened in 1660? **The monarchy was restored under Charles II.**
2. Did 1688 produce equal rights for everyone? **No.**
3. Is Enlightenment thought one anti-religious position? **No; it is a diverse intellectual field.**

Build an exam answer

1. Explain the Stuart conflicts.
2. Identify Commonwealth and Restoration changes.
3. Discuss 1688–89 with limits to inclusion.
4. Connect print and commerce with readership.
5. Use a literary form to demonstrate the relation.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not substitute a monarch list for analysis or assume progress affected all groups equally.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

How did political change and public debate create conditions for literary development?

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The period’s literary changes cannot be explained by a simple sequence of kings. Disputes about sovereignty, religion, taxation, and representation altered the purposes of writing and the institutions through which it circulated. Civil conflict made questions of obedience and freedom urgent; the Restoration changed theatrical opportunities without erasing those questions.

Eighteenth-century commercial and print culture created further possibilities for discussion. Periodicals could address recurring readers in a conversational voice, while satire examined ambition and public reputation. The expansion of a reading public did not mean equal participation: property, education, gender, and empire continued to distribute authority unevenly.

The Enlightenment supplies a useful framework for inquiry and improvement, but its ideals require qualification. Literature can both promote reasoned judgement and expose the exclusions within claims to universal progress. Context therefore includes contradictions rather than a single shared worldview.

A strong historical answer connects these conditions with a particular formal development, such as the periodical essay or comedy of manners. It explains how an institution or pressure changes the relationship between writer, work, and audience instead of treating a text as an illustration of a date.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Discuss the concept of the Divine Right of Kings and its political consequences during the Stuart reigns.
2. Evaluate the role of the English Civil War in shaping the relationship between the monarchy and Parliament.
3. Analyse the cultural and literary impact of the Restoration period, with special reference to Restoration comedy.
4. How did the Enlightenment challenge traditional religious and political authority in 18th-century Britain?

5. Examine the influence of the French Revolution on the transition from the Enlightenment to Romanticism in British literature.